



Photographs are not just bits of paper; they're priceless memories. But prints fade with time. Now you could convert your images to digital format by scanning them, and store them on your PC. This is one method of storing images, still widely used.

Digital cameras, on the other hand, capture information and transfer data in digital formats such as JPEG, TIFF and so on. It took a while for digital cameras to gain mass acceptance though, because of their high cost—and the fact that you needed a computer to transfer the data.

As PC penetration increased, so did the usage of such devices as digital cameras. This has motivated manufacturers to bring out better digital cameras loaded with the best features. Indeed, these cameras have improved tremendously in past two years. The resolution has skyrocketed, the feature list now includes high-end, professional features such as 1/10,000 shutter speed, white balance modes and 10X optical zoom for landscape and outdoor photography.

People who used point-and-shoot cameras

all their life and who had never heard of terms such as macro-mode or sepia, now talk in a language that makes even professionals look up and take notice. That's largely due to the proliferation of digital cameras and the features that come with them.

The charge coupled device or CCD, which replaces the film in a digital camera, has also witnessed tremendous refinement. From a VGA camera, to 5.0 effective megapixels packed in the same device is a huge leap. LCD screens used in such cameras have changed too—from dark screens that needed to be held in front of the eye to the vividly colourful, crystal-clear LCD screens of today. Lack of storage space used to be an issue, because early digital cameras couldn't store many images, but now memory expansion slots let users add memory at will.

Another major boost is now coming from printer manufacturers, who are designing their printers to either directly read the removable memory storage and print, or plug the camera directly for photo printing. This bypasses the computer completely.

With a further drop in prices, digital cameras are going to be as common as the television in the not-so-distant future. Even now, there are hundreds of thousands of digital cameras around us, and this number can only increase as better technology arrives, along with more affordable prices.

Tricks to be a Sharp Shooter

- Brace yourself and avoid excessive hand movement to get those sharp photos. The camera needs to be stable to get a good focus, and adjust the white balance and metering.
- Use the flash wisely. In bright sunlight, where parts of your subject might be darker, use 'flash fill' to brighten up the darker areas for a balanced photo.
- Flashes only have a range of up to 10 to 12 feet so don't bother using it for objects farther than this. Use red-eye reduction to get rid of the monster-glow eyes.
- The overall tone of a photo looks different in certain kinds of lighting. Experiment with the white balance and if you want more natural colours, manually set the white balance to match the scene before you shoot.
- For portrait shots, avoid a crowded background, as this tends to take away the attention from the subject. Either move to a more neutral background or adjust the f-stop to the widest setting possible so that the background is as out of focus as possible—this creates clarity for the main subject.
- Use the Flash-fill mode, especially when shooting portraits as this eliminates harsh shadows on the subject. Avoid such shots at high-noon as this creates very harsh shadows.
- Flash reflectors are great for filling out harsh shadows. You can use a simple car window reflector as a flash reflector or even a large white board. Reflect light on the subject's face to eliminate shadows and you will have great portraits.
- If you are going to use your digital camera for outdoor shoots, use a neck strap as this is a very delicate device and you may drop it accidentally, resulting in considerable damage.
- Always keep in mind while taking a snap that you should not focus on very bright, or very dark areas. Instead, keep the focus on neutral areas where lighting conditions are not extreme.
- If you are shooting, say, a building with the bright sky in the background, keep rest of the settings such as the white balance to auto and increase exposure by one point. In the image the building will retain all the details but the sky will look less bright.
- While taking close-up photographs, always turn on the macro mode. This is the minimum range at which the camera can take a photograph of the target.

Market overview

So far, there was no proper channel in the market to buy digital cameras from. Buying cameras from the grey market was a risky proposition because they cost only marginally less and came with no guarantee. But now most companies—such as Canon and Sony—have a presence, and offer ample after-sales support and service.

Keeping pace with technology, the digital camera has also moved up the ladder, at the same time witnessed a drop in price. Now a regular 2 megapixel camera can be bought for as little as Rs 15,000 to 18,000. And a 5.0 megapixel camera with 3X optical zoom can be yours for Rs 50,000.

There are also cheap alternatives such as the BenQ 1300, which captures images at 1.3 megapixel, and costs around Rs 10,000. Other players such as Creative and Logitech have something to offer too, if you're looking at VGA (640 x 480) cameras. These offer basic features such as macro mode and shutter mode, and also let you record small movie clips.

Vendors that traditionally manufactured film-based cameras, such as Kodak, Nikon and Olympus, now have a complete range of digital cameras on offer.